

Fundamentals of Ecology

BS-Zoology

8th semester

Presented by:-

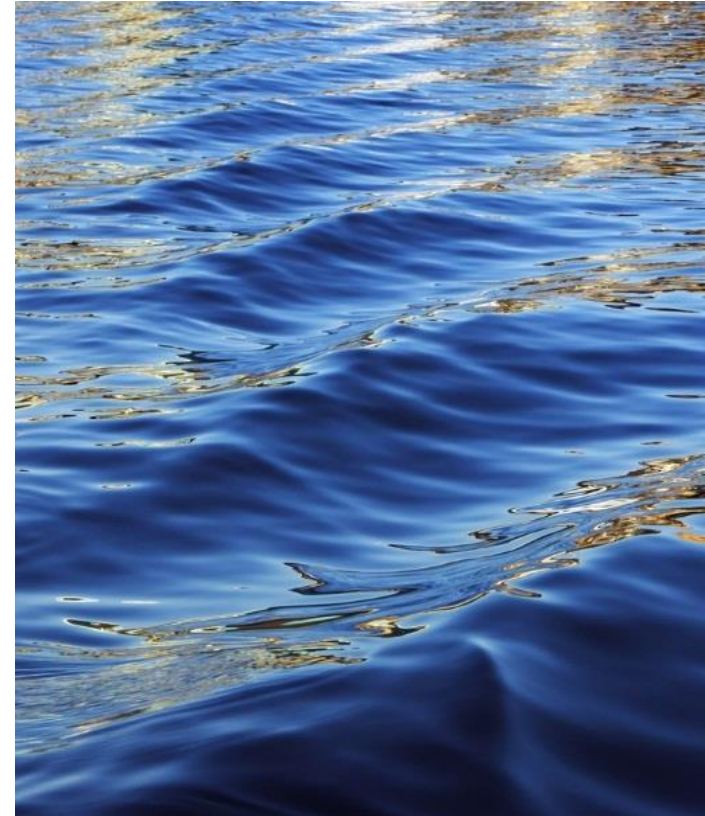
Laiba Qaisar (02)

Laraib ur Rehman (04)

Ayman (19)

Alia Jameel (30)

Zahra Anwar (25)



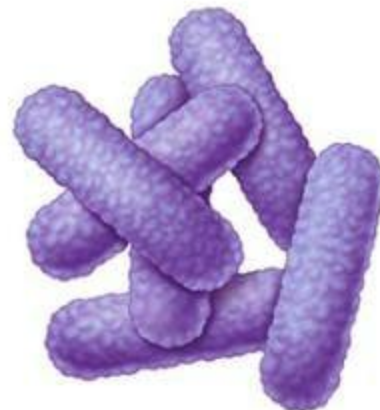
Fundamentals of Microbial Ecology

- Microbial ecology is the study of the interactions between microorganisms and their environment. It encompasses the relationships between microorganisms, their surroundings, and the impact they have on ecosystem.

Bacteria



Sphere-shaped
(cocci)



Rod-shaped
(bacilli)



Spiral-shaped
(spirochetes)

1. Microbial Diversity.

- Refers to the variety of different types of microorganisms in an environment.
- This diversity is crucial for ecosystem functions, such as nutrient cycling, waste decomposition, and food production.
 - Types of Microorganisms:-
- Bacteria: The most abundant microorganisms, found in almost every environment. They play crucial roles in nutrient cycling, such as nitrogen fixation and decomposition.
- Fungi: Fungi are important decomposers in terrestrial ecosystems and also form symbiotic relationships with plants (e.g., mycorrhizae).
- Protozoa: Single-celled eukaryotes that can be predators in microbial communities, consuming bacteria and algae.
- Viruses: Although they are not considered "living" organisms, viruses influence microbial populations by infecting and killing bacteria.
- Archaea: Similar to bacteria but genetically distinct, they are often found in extreme environments (extremophiles) like hot springs, salt lakes, or acidic environments.

Microbial Diversity in Different Environments:

Soil: Rich in microorganisms that perform functions like nitrogen fixation and organic matter decomposition.

Water: Aquatic microbial communities are essential for nutrient cycling in both freshwater and marine ecosystems.

Extreme Environments: Microbes like thermophiles (heat-loving) or halophiles (salt-loving) can thrive in environments with extreme conditions, such as geothermal vents or hypersaline lakes

3:Microbial Interactions in Ecosystems:

Microorganisms interact in complex ways within their environments, and these interactions can shape the structure and function of microbial communities. These interactions are crucial for understanding microbial ecology.

Symbiosis: A close relationship between two or more organisms that can be: Mutualism: Both organisms benefit (e.g., nitrogen-fixing bacteria and legume plants).

Commensalism: One organism benefits while the other is unaffected (e.g., skin bacteria on humans).

Parasitism: One organism benefits at the expense of the other (e.g., pathogenic bacteria that cause diseases).

Competition: Microorganisms often compete for resources like nutrients, space, and light. For example, in the soil, bacteria and fungi may compete for organic carbon sources.

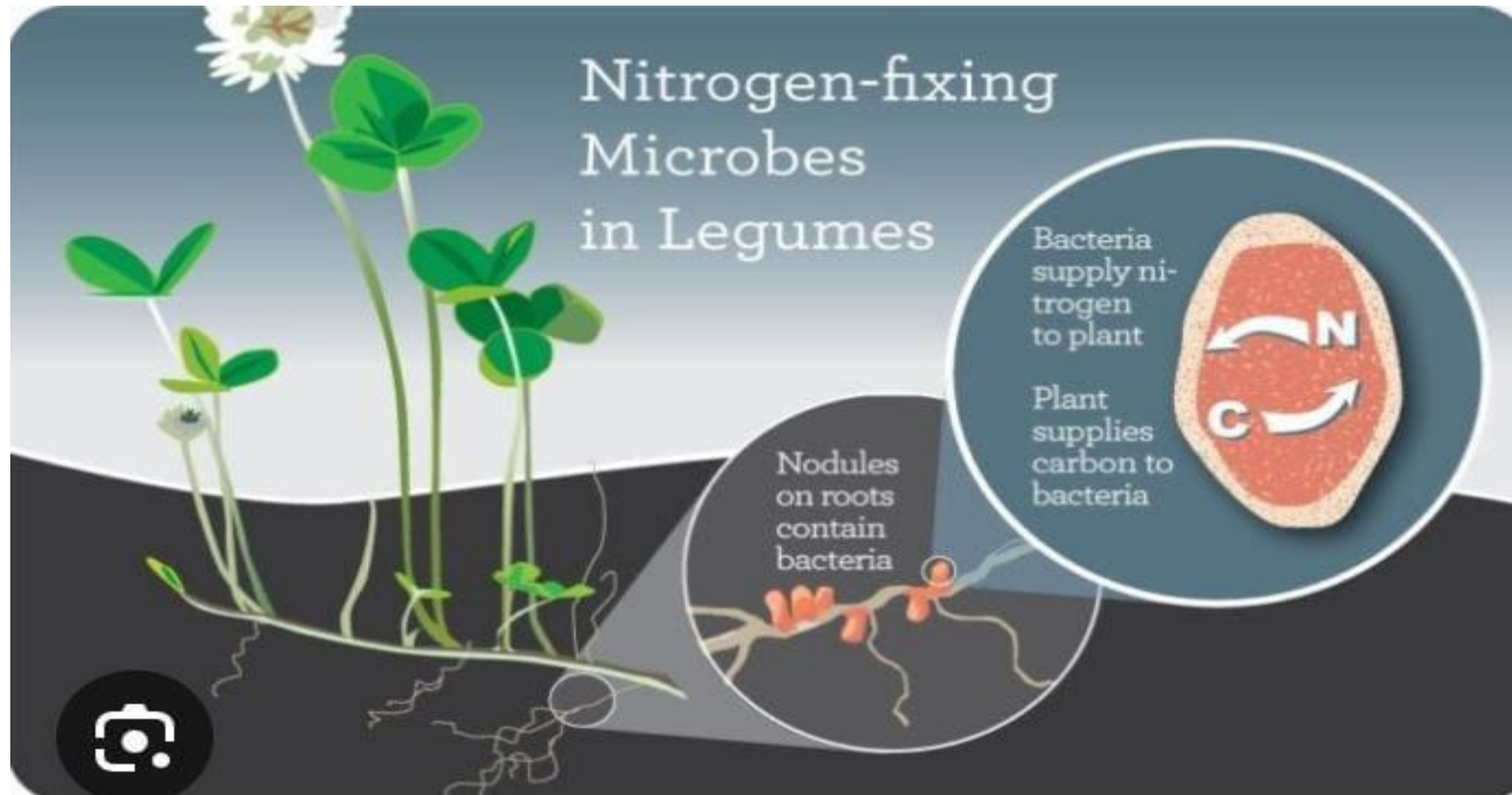
Antagonism: Some microorganisms produce *antibiotics* or other chemicals to inhibit the growth of competing species (e.g., *Penicillium* fungi produce penicillin to fight bacterial competitors).

Quorum Sensing: Many bacteria communicate through chemical signals to coordinate their behavior. This process allows bacteria to work together in large groups (e.g., in biofilm formation or virulence expression)

4: Microbial Communities and Ecosystem Services:

- Microbial communities form the backbone of ecological processes, contributing to the functioning and stability of ecosystems.
- **Decomposition:** Microorganisms are primary decomposers in the ecosystem. They break down complex organic matter (such as dead plants and animals) into simpler molecules, recycling nutrients like carbon, nitrogen, and phosphorus.
- **Nutrient Cycling:** Microorganisms are key players in the biogeochemical cycles, ensuring that nutrients are recycled in the environment.
- **Carbon Cycle:** Microbes decompose organic matter and release carbon back into the atmosphere as carbon dioxide (CO₂). Some microbes, like cyanobacteria, also contribute to carbon fixation.
- **Nitrogen Cycle:** Nitrogen-fixing bacteria convert atmospheric nitrogen (N₂) into usable forms (ammonia, nitrites, and nitrates) for plants, while other bacteria denitrify compounds to return nitrogen to the atmosphere.
- **Sulfur Cycle:** Sulfate-reducing bacteria and sulfur-oxidizing bacteria play roles in cycling sulfur in ecosystems.
- **Phosphorus Cycle:** Microbes decompose organic matter and help release phosphorus into the soil, making it available for plants.
- **Biofilms:** Many microbes, particularly bacteria, form biofilms, which are clusters of microorganisms that attach to surfaces. Biofilms are involved in various environmental processes, including wastewater treatment and the formation of tooth plaque.

Nitrogen fixing Microbes in Legumes



5:Microbial Adaptation to Environmental Stress:

- Microorganisms are incredibly adaptable and can thrive in a variety of environments, even under extreme conditions. The mechanisms by which microbes adapt to changing environments are fundamental to microbial ecology:
- Genetic Adaptation: Microbes evolve rapidly through mutations and horizontal gene transfer (HGT). HGT allows for the rapid spread of beneficial traits (like antibiotic resistance) within microbial communities.
- Dormancy and Spores: Some microorganisms can enter a dormant state or form spores to withstand environmental stress like temperature extremes, dehydration, or lack of nutrients.
- Extremophiles: Microbes known as extremophiles can survive in harsh conditions that would be lethal to most organisms. Examples include:
- Thermophiles: Heat-loving microbes that thrive in hot environments like hot springs.
- Halophiles: Salt-loving microbes that live in saline environments such as salt lakes.
- Acidophiles: Microbes that thrive in highly acidic conditions (low pH)
- Alkaliphiles: Microbes that thrive in basic (high pH) environments.

6:Microbial Biogeography

The distribution of microbial populations across different environments is known as microbial biogeography. This field studies how physical and environmental factors such as temperature, moisture, salinity, and oxygen influence the distribution and diversity of microorganisms.

Spatial Distribution: Microbes are found in a wide range of habitats, from soil and oceans to extreme environments like volcanoes or polar ice caps.

Temporal Changes: Microbial communities can change over time due to factors such as seasonal variations, nutrient availability, or disturbances like fire, floods, or human activities.

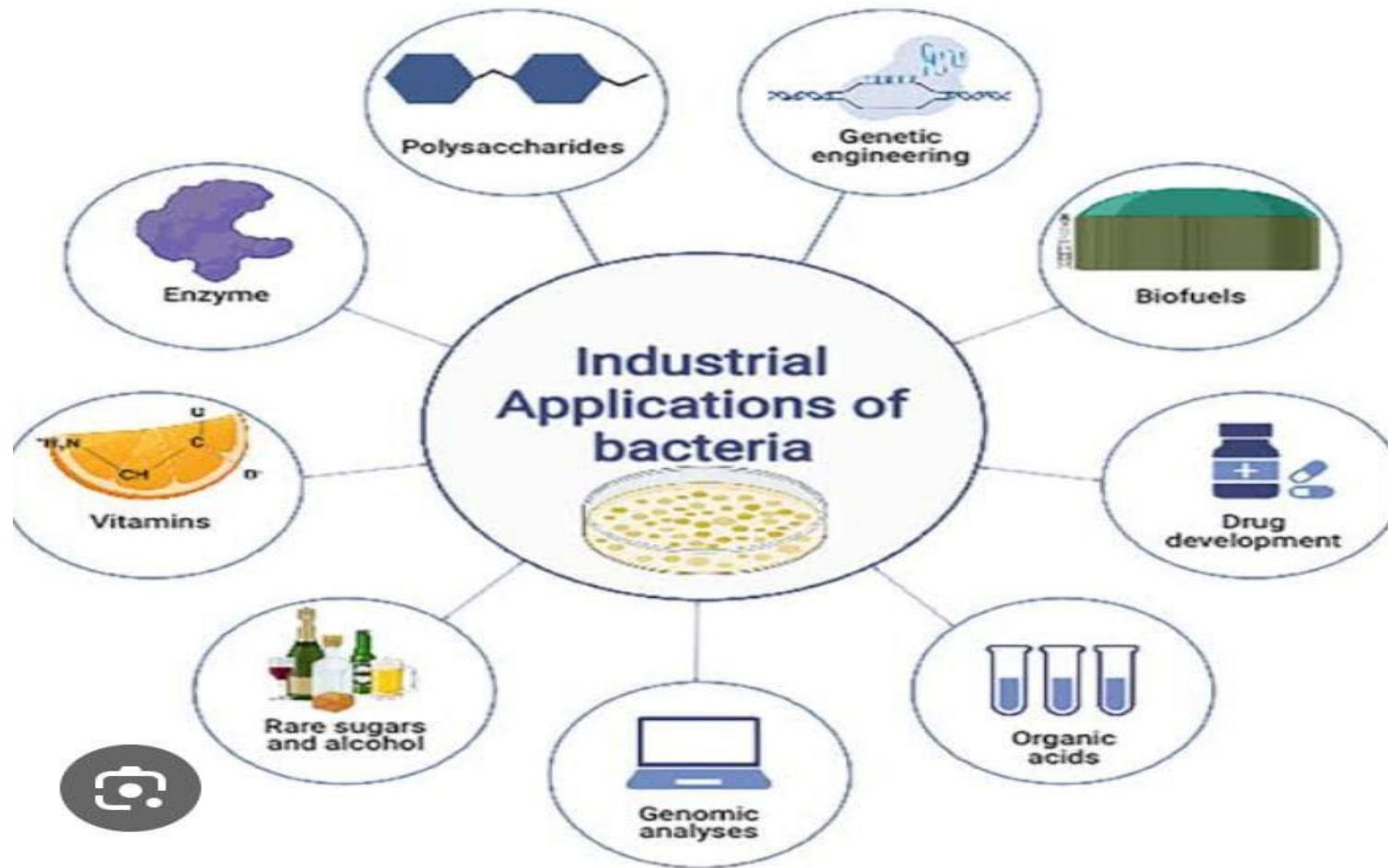
7: Human Impact on Microbial Ecology.

- Humans can significantly alter microbial communities through various activities, such as: -
- **Pollution**: Chemicals, heavy metals, and pesticides can disrupt microbial communities in ecosystems. Microbes can either adapt to these pollutants (e.g., by developing resistance) or die off.
- **Climate Change**: Changes in temperature, precipitation, and humidity can affect microbial diversity and function. For instance, warmer temperatures can accelerate decomposition rates or increase the spread of disease-causing microbes.
- **Antibiotic Resistance**: The overuse of antibiotics in medicine and agriculture has led to the emergence of antibiotic-resistant bacteria, which poses a significant challenge to public health.
- **Agriculture**: Practices like monoculture farming, over-fertilization, and pesticide use can alter soil microbial communities, impacting soil health, nutrient cycling, and crop yields.
- **Bioremediation**: Microbial communities are harnessed to clean up environmental contaminants in a process called bioremediation, where microbes degrade pollutants such as oil spills or industrial waste.

8:Applications of Microbial Ecology

- The principles of microbial ecology have practical applications in various fields:
- **Agriculture:** Understanding soil microbiomes helps improve crop yields and soil fertility. Using beneficial microbes (e.g., nitrogen-fixing bacteria) in farming can reduce the need for chemical fertilizers.
- **Environmental Conservation:** Microbial communities are used in bioremediation to clean up pollutants and restore ecosystems, such as cleaning oil spills or wastewater treatment.
- **Medicine:** The study of the human microbiome (the collection of microbes in and on the human body) is crucial for understanding human health. Microbial ecology helps in managing diseases, antibiotics, probiotics, and even cancer therapies.
- **Food Production:** Microorganisms play a key role in *fermentation* processes used in the production of foods and beverages such as yogurt, cheese, bread, and alcoholic drinks. Understanding microbial ecology can improve these processes and ensure food safety.

Industrial Applications of Bacteria



Conclusion

Microbial ecology is essential for understanding the intricate relationships between microorganisms, their environments, and their ecosystems. It plays a key role in a wide range of applications—from agriculture and medicine to environmental conservation and climate change mitigation. By studying microbial interactions and their impact on larger ecological processes, we can improve sustainability, public health, and environmental management.